1959 and the grant of asylum to His Holiness the Dalai Lama changed Chinese threat perception regarding what had been until then limited skirmishes on the India–China border. A careful reading of the long history of Tibet's relations with China may have led to a more nuanced posture on India's part, even while it granted refuge to the Dalai Lama.

Since the border war of 1962, the focus in India has been narrowly on the study and analysis of Chinese foreign and security policies without appreciating that these can only yield useful insights when set in the larger frame of the country's world view.

~

During the forty years and more that I was engaged with China in different capacities, I became increasingly aware of how little we really know about a country which is now a contiguous neighbour, a powerful adversary and a challenge which manifests itself in multiple dimensions – political, economic, technological and even cultural. This book is an attempt to create among Indians a broader understanding of China and the history and culture that have shaped its ethos and world view through the centuries, down to the present day. It is not enough for India to have a handful of Chinese-knowing diplomats and a small group of China scholars possessed of a relatively deep familiarity with China. The larger constituency of educated Indians must also have such familiarity. This is because there are now many more points of contact between the two countries, and given China's growing regional and global profile, our engagement with many other countries is also impacted by China's presence in them. This presence is not only of the Chinese state but of a number of other actors, such as Chinese businesspeople. Moreover, we need to be familiar not only with how China looks at India but also with how China shapes its relations with those countries which are important to India, such as our immediate neighbours in the subcontinent. The China factor will keep popping up in many of our foreign policy calculations.

Though this is not a book about India–China relations, it does attempt an Indian perspective on the China story. It also provides, wherever possible, a